Spain: Art Restoration & Heritage Conservation

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Executive Summary

- **The sector is specialised and coordination-heavy.** Work spans historic buildings, fine and decorative art, archaeology and documentary collections. Public, ecclesiastical and private custodians must align on evidence, funding, access and treatment; the IPCE alone reports close to 100 immovable-heritage projects annually (IPCE).
- **The direction is preventive, digital and data-rich.** Monitoring, risk assessment, scientific imaging and 3D documentation increasingly support long-term care. AI is primarily expert decision support—not a substitute for conservators' judgement (IPCE).

Sector Context: How the Work Runs

Engagements move through diagnosis, scientific analysis, treatment planning and approvals, intervention, documentation, and follow-up monitoring. Multidisciplinary teams combine conservator-restorers with architects, scientists, historians and specialist contractors. Religious projects add church governance and liturgical-use constraints; secular work includes museums, municipalities, foundations, collectors and public procurement. The constant tension is enabling access while protecting authenticity, traceability and physical fabric (IPCE).

Forces Reshaping the Sector

- **Prevent before treating:** Spain prioritises continuous identification and control of deterioration factors, increasing demand for condition records, environmental data and risk-led maintenance (IPCE).
- **Digitise for conservation—not display alone:** EU policy promotes high-quality 3D capture. Useful models require documented accuracy, metadata, interoperability and a clear purpose (European Commission).
- **Make fragmented data reusable:** European strategy prioritises trusted, interoperable data and faster AI, 3D and XR adoption, while recognising skills, funding and data-silo barriers (2025–2030 strategy).
- **Coordinate accountable decisions:** Spanish religious heritage explicitly depends on cooperation between public administrations and ecclesiastical institutions; treatment choices must remain explainable and professionally governed (IPCE).

AI Projects Already in the Industry

- **PERCEIVE:** uses AI processing, image-based rendering and 3D visualisation to reconstruct and predict colour change across paintings, textiles, photographs, sculpture and digital art.
- **RePAIR:** combines computer vision, AI and robotics to match and reassemble large collections of archaeological fragments, including shattered Pompeii frescoes.
- **AI4Culture:** provides tools and datasets for transcription, image analysis, translation and metadata enrichment, demonstrating near-term value in documentation.

Client implication: credible opportunities will augment diagnosis, prioritisation and documentation while preserving human approval, source traceability and a firm boundary between evidence-based reconstruction and speculation.

Selected references: IPCE conservation · IPCE preventive plan · EU heritage data strategy · PERCEIVE · RePAIR · AI4Culture